

Notes That Last

Ada Example

This short paper is invented for the Claude Cowork Kit's test fixture. It argues that a note survives only when a later piece of writing needs it. Notes kept for their own sake are rarely opened again, and a collection that grows without being written from becomes harder to trust with every addition.

The first claim is about use. A note that no topic note cites has no reader but its author, and its author has moved on. The second claim is about cost: every note added to a pile raises the price of finding any one of them.

The remedy the paper proposes is to write the synthesis first. Keep one living note for each topic, stating what you currently think, and let sources earn a fuller note only when that topic note cites them. A source that nothing cites can stay a single line until it is needed.

The paper closes with a test any reader can run: open a topic you care about and ask whether one note says what you think. If the answer is a folder of sources, the collection has been gathering rather than thinking.